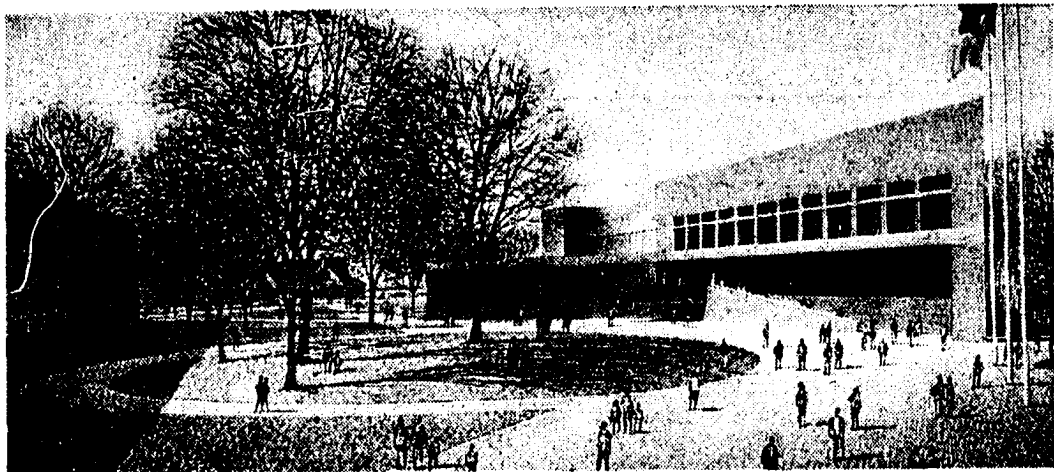




Sketch of the proposed Kennedy memorial for Cambridge—no floor plans yet.

Kennedy Library trial balloon

Given the political upheaval surrounding the Kennedy Library, you can't blame the building's sponsors for taking a cautious, finger-to-the-wind approach.

In a sense, the scaled down redesign of the complex that was recently announced is more in the nature of a trial balloon than a fully thought out building complex.

It's said that before the new design was unveiled, the architect, I. M. Pei, was asked to produce alternate designs for four other sites in the Boston area as a hedge against the possibility of being driven out of Cambridge.

Considering the despair that such a request must have created in Mr. Pei (who refused), it isn't surprising that the redesigned museum, long touted as the answer to widespread criticism of the earlier, much grander glass pyramid design, turns out to have a slightly perfunctory quality.

As many have already said, it's a kind of loosely pulled together assemblage of modish shapes that doesn't appear to be really in command of either its site or its program. It displays little of the design assurance that the earlier proposal, whatever its drawbacks, certainly had in abundance.

No one should blame Pei's office. In fact, you have to sympathize with anyone who is asked to solve, by purely architectural means, problems that were inherent in the very concept of siting such a building in this place.

If the museum seems a little unresolved, the rest of the complex is more so. The Kennedy School of Government and Institute of Politics has been separated from the museum and placed in a triangular

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structure that is much bigger than the museum itself and sits on the other side of a large courtyard called Commonwealth Plaza. Inquiry elicits the information that there are, in fact, no floor plans for this imposing edifice. Like a western storefront on an MGM backlot, what is shown on the model is merely a shell, created solely to complement the museum visually, a predesigned mold into which, at some future time, the various functions of the Kennedy School will presumably be poured.

Even this ghostly presence is more substantial than the proposal for the rest of the site, the so-called related facilities. Described at various times as a hotel, a condominium complex, and a park, sometimes with underground parking, this area in its present incarnation has become a parking lot, forming the uninspiring north edge of Commonwealth Plaza. Even Pei is among the many who believe that without some building on this part of the site, the whole composition falls apart. Yet nothing is being proposed.

I don't have space to comment on the broader issues raised by the Library and its impact on Harvard Square, but it's worth pointing out that whatever problems there are, the redesign hasn't changed them.

The building is smaller now, but it's the archives that have shrunk, not the tourist attraction. It's also been changed from concrete to brick, perhaps to accommodate what was thought to be local prejudice. And certainly it no longer turns its back to its surroundings, as it once so blatantly did.

But as far as its effect on the social economic ecology of Harvard Square is concerned, the Kennedy Library doesn't pretend to be anything but what it always was—one more pit stop on an asphalt Freedom Trail, a part of the car culture of a wider America rather than of the interdependent, close-grained, pedestrian community of Harvard Square.

When you come there, it will almost certainly be by vehicle from somewhere else, and you'll leave the same way. You get out of your vehicle and enter the building and find yourself in a very large room with a long window overlooking the Charles. This room, ironically, is empty except for symbols: a tapestry, say the designers, or maybe a bust of Kennedy. Leaving this room, you pass on through a series of smaller spaces with permanent exhibitions on the presidency and on the life of Kennedy, exhibits ordered in such a way as to lead you back outside. Somewhere on an upper floor, unseen, scholars will have space to work with the presidential documents.

No matter how much you may like it as a visitor, it's not something you're going to go back to. It's a one-shot thing, a media experience rather than one of genuine life. It won't have much resonance with Harvard Square's other activities, and no one pretends that it will.

What its impact on those other activities will be, of course, is a question that is now in the realm of political debate rather than architectural criticism.